While Honecker received all the professional accolades he could have hoped for, life at the matrimonial home also seems to have stabilised. That summer, he took Margot and the family to Poland for a month's vacation, their first together in several years. Twice a week, however, he slipped quietly away for hunting jaunts in the Polish countryside while Margot, wearing a bandana around her hair, played the simple hausfrau by doting on the children and preparing family meals. She remained an earthy, practical woman, capable of domestic toil.

Under cotton awnings protecting him from the blazing sun, Erich fussed over grandson Roberto, who was nearing his first birthday. 'He was a real grandpa, he really enjoyed this role,' says bodyguard, Bernd Bruckner. Over time his relationship with Roberto flourished and he was an exceptionally devoted grandfather and even taught his grandson to ride a pint-size bicycle. Besotted as he was, nothing was too much trouble. 'If Roberto wanted a toy from the West, he would get it,' recalled Lothar Herzog, the butler. 'There was a big dining room at the hunting lodge. At Christmas, half of the room was full of toys, and they were all for Roberto.'

On one occasion, he even took his grandson hunting and allowed him to take aim from the back of his souped-up Range Rover. Roberto bagged his first and only deer. On hearing of the adventure, Margot berated her husband for his irresponsibility in letting the child near a gun. 'When Grandma banned something,' Roberto recounted, 'it was final. Grandfather never took me with him again.'10 There was no argument, 'grandfather was a withdrawn loner, a shy person who never raised his voice in conversation and kept calm in every situation'.11

Back from holiday, Honecker headed to Moscow to sign the third treaty on friendship, cooperation and mutual assistance with the USSR, which, unlike the two previous accords, omitted references to German reunification and Allied special rights in Germany. By this point, Leonid Brezhnev – ashenfaced, overweight and prone to severe sleeplessness – presented a vision of decrepitude. Suffering from a disorder restricting blood flow within the brain; his ability to focus on tasks was failing, meaning big decisions and policy was left in the hands of his inner circle, namely Dmitry Ustinov of the Soviet Army, Yuri Andropov of the KGB and Foreign